

Jayson Tatum Has Been an Anomaly

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Executive Summary

Less than a year removed from an Achilles rupture, Jayson Tatum has already returned as one of the most versatile and impactful players in basketball, while carrying a similar load to what he handled before the injury.

It is rare to watch a former top-five player rebuild parts of his game in real time. The scoring and movement are not fully back yet. The burst, balance, and flow are still coming along, but he has already shown enough to suggest he can reach a similar level, maybe with a slightly more polished all-around game.

Now the Celtics are tied 3–3 with Philadelphia, and the demands are only growing. Until now, Tatum has been evaluated with his timeline in mind. Achilles ruptures rarely allow for a return this quick. Game 7 raises the stakes and forces a different standard.

Box Score Difference

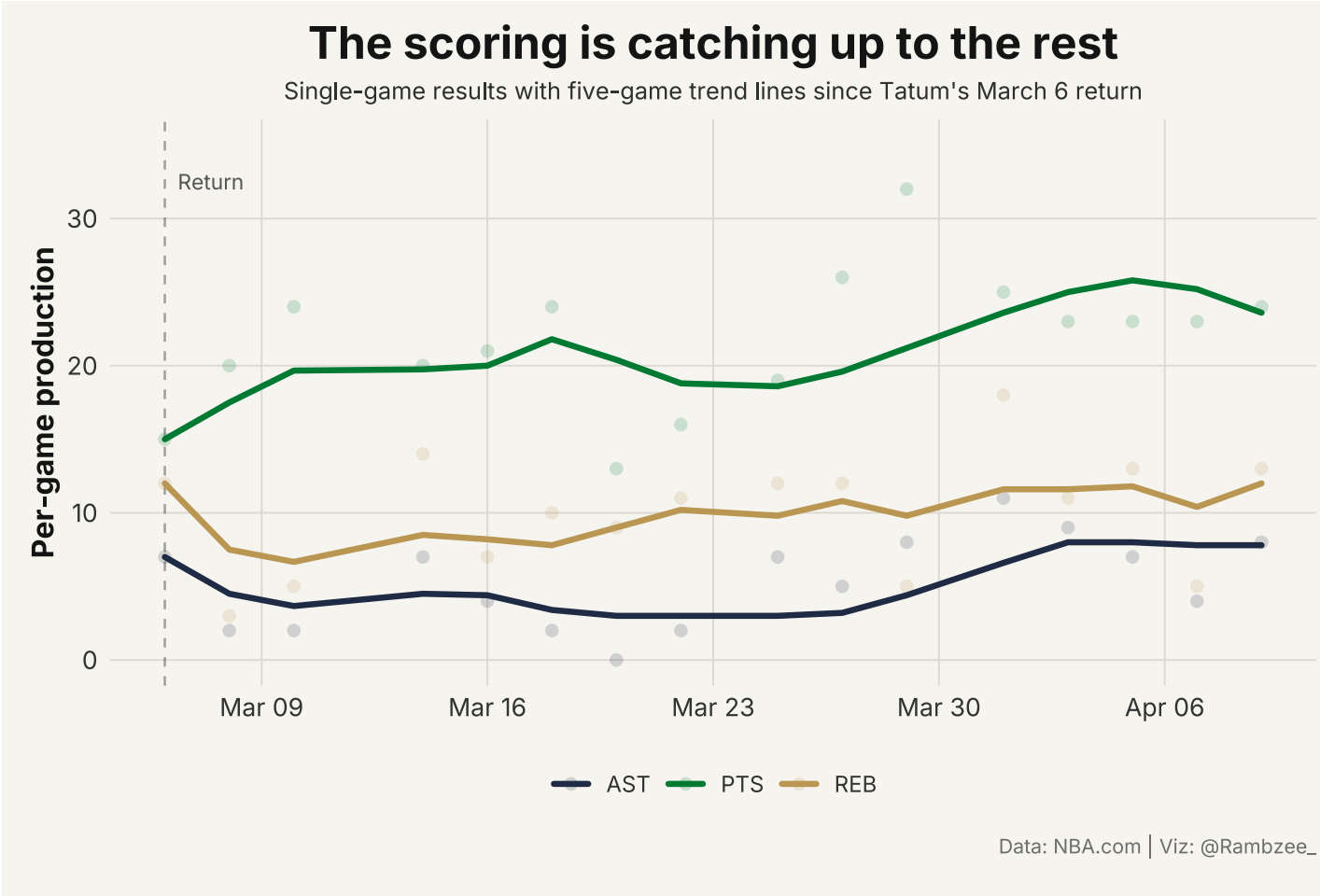
Table 1: Tatum’s regular-season profile before and after the Achilles return

Metric	2024-25	2025-26	Change
GP	72.0	16.0	—
PTS	26.8	21.8	-5.0
REB	8.7	10.0	+1.3
AST	6.0	5.3	-0.7
STL	1.1	1.4	+0.3
TOV	2.9	2.4	-0.5
FG%	45.2%	41.1%	-4.1%
3P%	34.3%	32.9%	-1.4%
2P%	55.9%	49.3%	-6.6%
eFG%	53.7%	49.3%	-4.4%
TS%	58.2%	54.1%	-4.1%

At face value, Tatum’s efficiency clearly dropped after his return. He was never an efficiency outlier as a scorer, but he consistently balanced league-average efficiency with elite volume, which creates massive value on its own. This season, he has struggled to reach that same scoring flow.

Early on, he had to rebuild confidence attacking the rim, playing through contact, and finding his jumper within the same process. Even with those drops, though, the impact held as the rest of his game traveled. His rebounding stayed elite, his defense remained active, and he gave Boston the playmaking lift it needed while keeping turnovers low for the size of his role.

The Ramp Up



The Impact Is Already Star Level

Table 2: Boston’s regular-season lineup performance with and without Jayson Tatum

Group	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET
Tatum ON	522	123.2	111.8	+11.4
Tatum OFF	3424	120.7	113.4	+7.3
ON - OFF	–	2.5	-1.6	+4.1

Boston was good without Tatum this season, but his minutes still popped. In a small regular-season sample, Boston was +11.4 per 100 with him on the floor and +4.1 better than it was in the non-Tatum minutes overall. His return immediately brought two-way stability, ballhandling, and processing back to the lineup. Among Celtics players, his net rating trailed only Neemias Queta (+13.1) and Hugo González (+12.3).

The Rebounding Is Still Elite

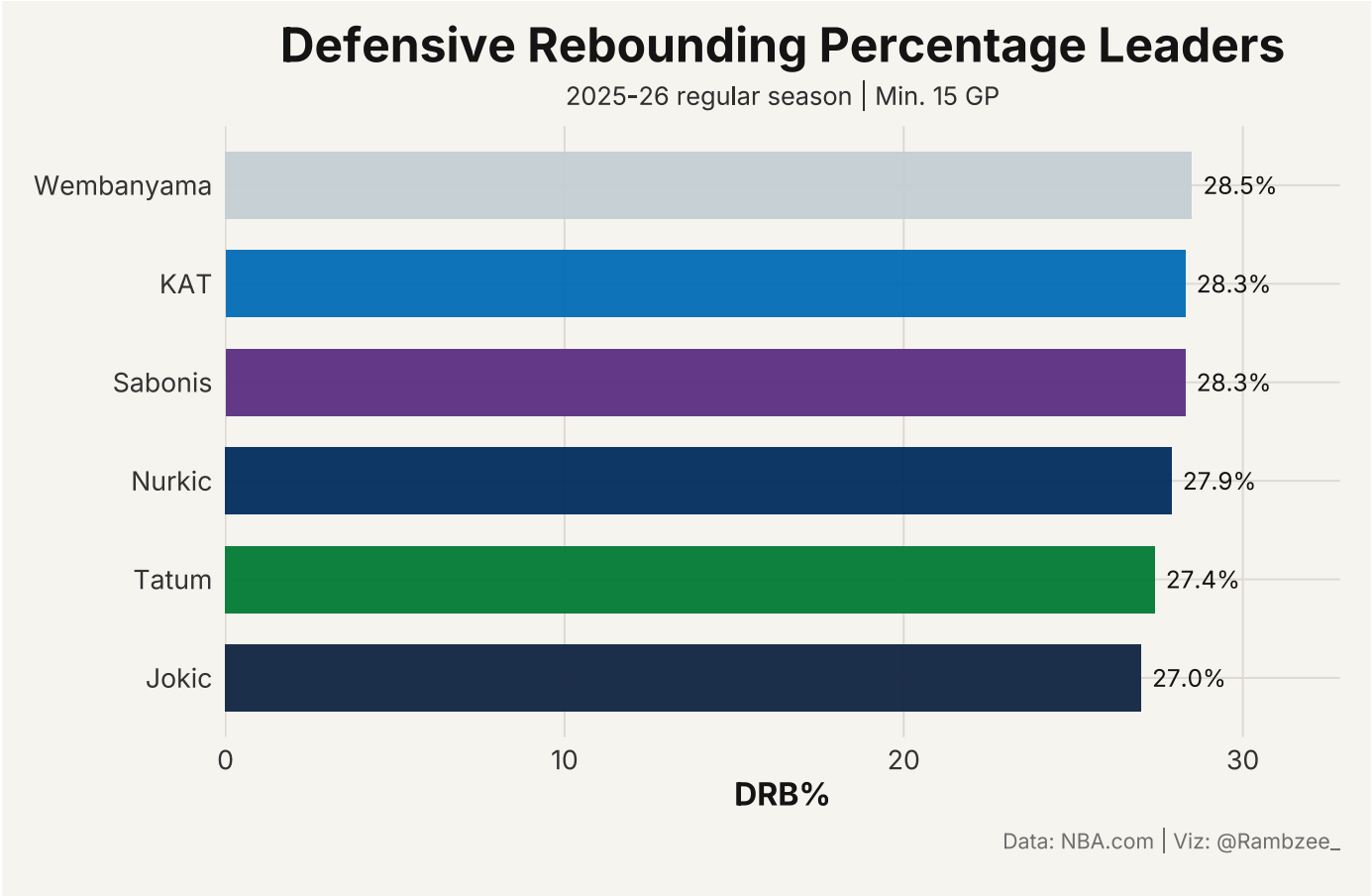
Table 3: Most rebounds per game from Tatum’s March 6 return through the end of the regular season | Min. 15 GP

Rank	Player	Team	RPG
1	Nikola Jokic	DEN	13.6
2	Victor Wembanyama	SAS	12.3
3	Karl-Anthony Towns	NYK	11.9
4	Donovan Clingan	POR	11.8
5	Rudy Gobert	MIN	11.4
6	Bam Adebayo	MIA	10.7
7	Evan Mobley	CLE	10.0
7	Jalen Duren	DET	10.0
7	Jayson Tatum	BOS	10.0

Tatum’s rebounding can be underappreciated, but it has long been one of the steadiest parts of his game. Since returning, he has lived in the same range as centers on the glass.

That gives Boston more lineup flexibility and more margin when the offense is not clicking. Even when the scoring rhythm is shaky, he can still finish possessions and keep the Celtics out of rotation-heavy scramble situations.

The volume backs it up. Tatum ranked seventh in rebounds per game after his return, and his 26.5% defensive rebounding rate ranked sixth in the league. This is not a new development either: he has ranked in the 90th percentile or higher in defensive rebounds for his position every season of his career.



The Playmaking Has Held the Offense Together

Table 4: Tatum’s playmaking indicators during the return season

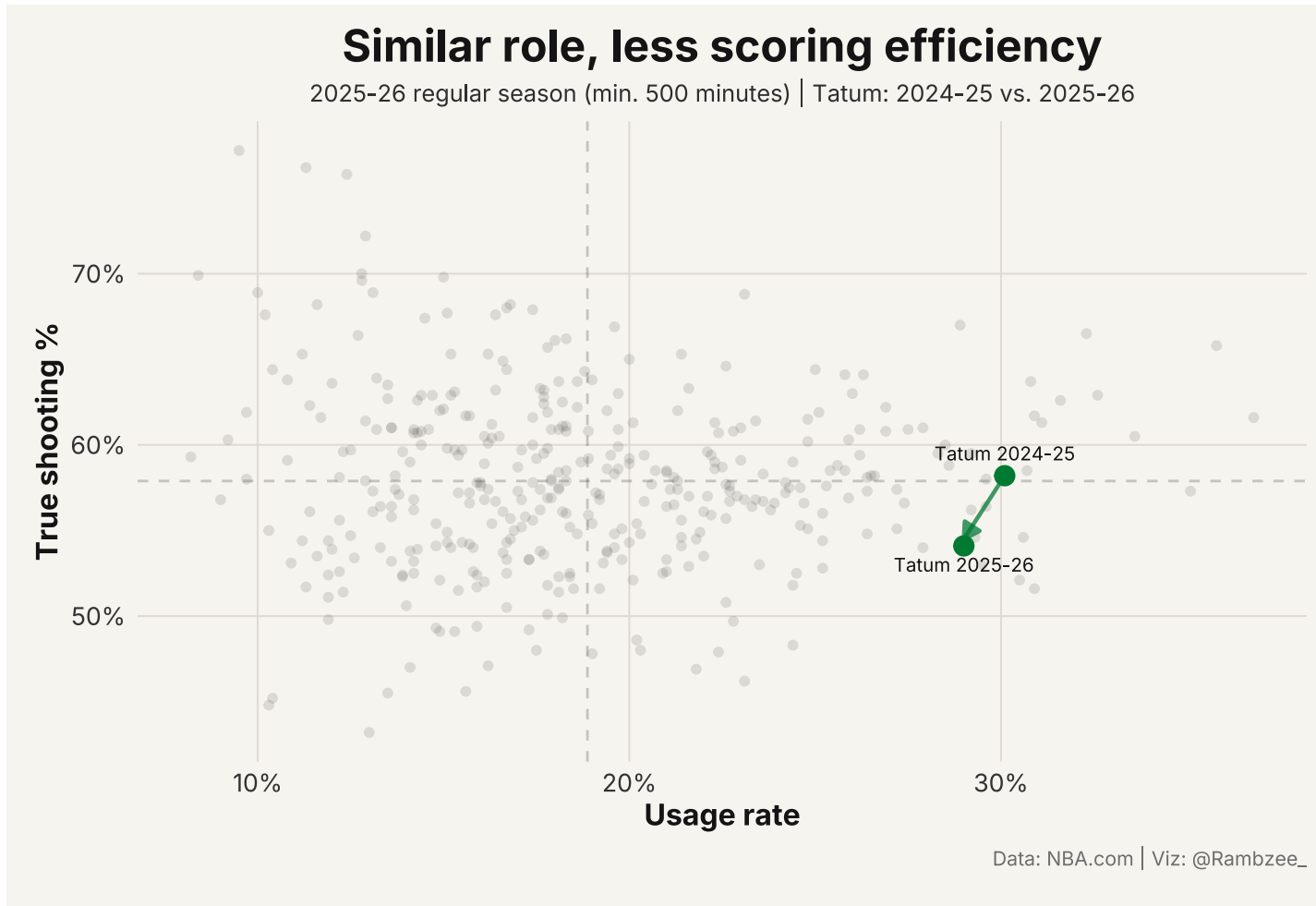
Indicator	Value	Context
On-ball share	29.0%	Essentially unchanged role size
Last season on-ball share	30.1%	Pre-injury baseline
Potential assists	15.4	91st percentile
Rim assists	3.0	89th percentile

The playmaking may be the clearest sign that Boston’s reliance on Tatum never really wavered.

His on-ball share barely moved from last season, which shows how unshielded his return has been. The Celtics let him initiate, read the defense, and solve possessions when the first action stalled, not just to get him reps, but because they needed him to.

The passing indicators show his growth as a game-reader. His potential assists and rim assists point to creation that is actually shifting the defense, not just swinging the ball and collecting easy “one-mores.” He has been getting downhill, drawing help, reading the second layer, and making passes a full beat ahead of the defense. The scoring rhythm is still coming back, but the control is already there.

League Context: Usage and Efficiency



That same responsibility shows up in the usage profile. Tatum is operating in a very similar role, with his usage barely moving from about 30% pre-injury to roughly 29% this season. The difference is the efficiency, which dipped below his usual standard in the regular season. In the playoffs, that has started to look more like his norm.

The Next Phase of the Ramp-Up

Table 5: Tatum’s 2026 playoff production through six playoff games

Metric	Value	Note
MPG	36.3	
PTS	23.3	
REB	10.7	
AST	6.8	Career playoff high
STL	1.2	
TOV	2.8	
FG%	47.5%	Career playoff high
3P%	36.5%	
2P%	59.2%	Career playoff high
eFG%	56.9%	Career playoff high
TS%	60.8%	Career playoff high

Through six games, Tatum has averaged 23.3 points, 10.7 rebounds, and 6.8 assists against just 2.8 turnovers on 60.8% true shooting, a playoff career high. The efficiency jump is not limited to TS%. He is also at playoff career highs in several efficiency metrics, while carrying major playmaking responsibility despite uneven shooting from the teammates around him.

Playoff Ranking

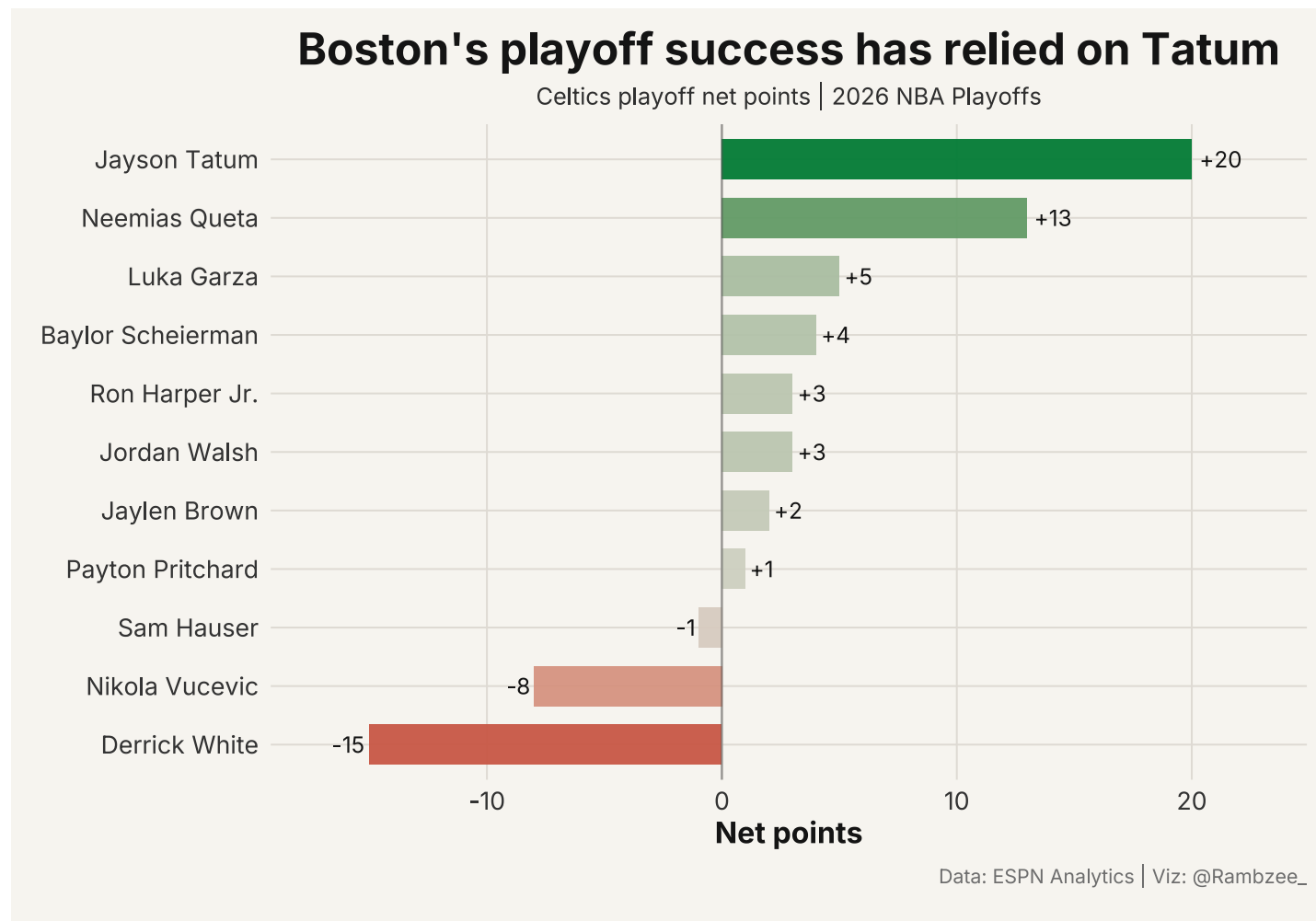
Table 6: Where Tatum ranks among 2026 playoff leaders

Category	Rank	Player	Value
Points	10	Scottie Barnes	24.2
	11	Jamal Murray	23.7
	12	Donovan Mitchell	23.3
	12	Jayson Tatum	23.3
	14	LeBron James	23.2
Rebounds	1	Nikola Jokic	13.2
	2	Karl-Anthony Towns	11.3
	3	Deandre Ayton	10.8
	4	Rudy Gobert	10.7
	5	Jayson Tatum	10.7
Assists	1	Nikola Jokic	9.5
	2	Scottie Barnes	9.0
	3	LeBron James	8.3
	4	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	8.0
	5	Jrue Holiday	7.2
	6	Jayson Tatum	6.8

That all-around production shows up clearly on the playoff leaderboards. He ranks 12th in points, fifth in rebounds, and sixth in assists, joining Jokic as the only other player top 12 in all three.

Playoff Team Context

Net Points Definition: Net Points is a play-by-play based metric that assigns credit and blame for every possession while a player is on the floor, capturing scoring, turnovers, defense, and context beyond the box score. It reflects how much a player actually moved the score, not just what they produced individually.



Boston's path forward has run through Tatum.

These are essentially his 17th through 22nd games back from an Achilles rupture. He is playing 36.3 minutes per game, 20th in the playoffs, less than a year removed from an injury that has derailed so many careers. Yet it has not been enough. Despite taking a 3–1 lead, Boston has been pushed to Game 7 as Philadelphia has tightened the series, raised the pressure on both ends, and forced the Celtics to ask even more of him.

The support around him has been inconsistent, and some rotation decisions have amplified it. Key pieces like Derrick White and Nikola Vučević have struggled, while other options have barely been explored. Players like Luka Garza and Ron Harper Jr. have produced in small bursts, but in limited minutes. Whether that production would translate is a different question, but the lack of experimentation has stood out as the series tightened.

What Game 7 Means for Tatum and the Celtics

Table 7: Jayson Tatum's career Game 7 averages

GP	MIN	PTS	REB	AST	TS%	Record
7	41.5	26.7	9.3	5.1	60.8%	5-2

Table 8: Tatum's best Game 7 performance

Date	Opponent	PTS	REB	AST	TS%	Note
May 14, 2023	vs PHI	51	13	5	74.6%	<i>NBA Game 7 playoff record</i>

Tatum has been here before. Across seven career Game 7s, he has averaged 26.7 points, 9.3 rebounds, and 5.1 assists on 60.8% true shooting, with a 5–2 record. His 51-point game against Philadelphia in 2023 remains the NBA playoff Game 7 scoring record.

The context is different this time. He is less than a year removed from an Achilles rupture. Tatum has already done more than anyone could have reasonably expected this soon. Now Boston needs him to be its best player once more in a Game 7 while he is still rebuilding the final pieces of his game.